Tech Session (11/5)

Issues:

- Transferring text from texts to email, copy / paste functionality
- Screenshotting, saving photos
- Apple watch health app
- (AT&T Internet Air)

Notes:

The resident while working with me to solve some basic issues with copy/paste functionality, along with questions about screenshotting, illustrated some of her concerns with dealing with her new phone. Having recently updated to a recent version of the iPhone, she has been struggling with all of the new features. She commented that this “evolution” of phones wasn’t helpful, and only caused her greater confusion. She had felt that she had a handle on her previous phone, but now was struggling with certain new gestures and functions. She was interested and engaged with learning technology, but was frustrated to have to “re-educate” herself when it comes to using her phone. She stated that many of her peers were afraid of pressing the wrong button and losing things, especially precious memories in photos. Uniquely, she had a nuanced understanding of her technology, and explained that she didn’t hold this concern of losing things on her phone, stating that “it’s still on there somewhere, I just might not be able to find it.” Additionally, while we were discussing the state of new technology, she commented on the differences on Apple and Android devices, and how there was both confusion and frustration there. She believed that in an attempt to differentiate themselves from each other, both brands made it harder to use their products.

I had asked her what kinds of things might be helpful to her as someone having to re-learn a lot of things with her new phone. She had stated that there was very little instruction given, and could benefit from it. In line with this, she took note on paper on how to screenshot and copy/paste, writing detailed instructions on gestures, behaviors, and screens, in steps so she can repeat the process when she wants to do it again. She went so far as to suggest an app that would hold instructions through instructional videos that would help with the “little things” that so often hold her up when using her phone.

She expressed some concern about changing her internet provider, and having to deal with the set-up process of switching from Xfinity to AT&T Internet Air. She had stated that she’ll ask me about the process and any problems that she has when we next meet.

Tech Session (11/06)

Issue: Using old(ish) android flip phone, and taking and deleting photos.

Notes:

I helped an older resident with their modern, likely mid-2010s flip phone. It had an android version that was relatively recent, but adjusted to work in the flip phone paradigm. If I had to assume, this phone was likely bought by someone hoping that it would be more familiar and helpful due to his age. However, this was evidently not the case. I am realizing that the touchscreen basic gestures are relatively intuitive (as research has shown as well), but the flip phone, and its limiting nature with navigation, proved very difficult. He struggled with navigating the keypad and navigation buttons, and their disconnection from the screen, alongside the button choices being indicated by word/buttons on certain sections of the screen made it incredibly difficult for the resident to function.

He wanted to learn about taking, saving, deleting, and viewing photos on this flip phone. He struggled with the numerous steps required to delete photos, needing to enter the photo app, navigate to the gallery button, enter an individual photo's option menu, select delete, and then confirm the deletion (all with different button interactions). He, like the previous resident from 11/5, needed to write down instructions for navigating the phone. With numbered steps, he essentially was programming the actions required to use the phone's functionalities.

Interestingly enough, he had a desktop computer in his apartment, which he stated he used, and was comfortable using and interacting with several key websites. While aware of and comfortable interacting with these sites, and his internet browser, he struggled and identified that he didn't know how to use other key functionalities of his computer. He stated that he wasn't aware of where to find things he was saving, and seemed generally unaware of the file explorer, or file structures.

His consistent issue was executive functioning and memory. To remedy this, he chose to write down instructions with visual descriptions of the buttons that are necessary.

Initial Reflection:

This interaction has sparked reflections and inquiries that are influential to my understanding of the problems of elder tech use, and how it can influence the solutions that I will eventually create. Firstly, it seems clear that touchscreen, at least in its basic functionality, is both intuitive and better than a more outdated button navigation system. This idea has been corroborated by research, but nonetheless reflects true in these initial interactions. Additionally, descriptions of online technology use are incredibly important and difficult. This resident's struggle with identifying what to call/notate certain buttons and actions with the phone shows me how important it will be to be aware of descriptions in my design. On the notation, this pattern reveals to me that memory could very well be something that I target with my solution, as it seems like a barrier that could be incredibly disabling in technology use.

With navigation, I am wondering whether or not a repeated motion in a series of interactions (e.g. navigating to photos, selecting a photo, and choosing to delete it) should use the same button with a similar position? Would that be helpful, to simplify the interactions, or create greater confusion, trying to remember which screen or repetition leading to confusion around what part of the process they are in. I also noticed that the second resident's technology use seemed different with the first resident when it comes to device vs. function. While the first resident seemed to use her phone for everything, the second resident had a computer that he used primarily for a limited list of key websites, and nothing else.

These ideas, understanding technology in these linear ways is something that I need to spend time understanding, and recognize as important to my design process. How can I positively engage with the kinds of linear thinking around technology use in my designing?